success on taxes. Unfortunately, most of the statistics quoted were contradictory and confusing, leading to the impression that data was being fudged.

- The first off the block was the Finance Minister, who, on 17 May 2017, stated that *91 lakh* tax payers had been added to the tax net as a result of action taken by the Income Tax Department.
- In reply to Unstarred Question No 2017 in Rajya Sabha on 1 August 2017, it was stated that *33 lakh* new tax payers were added to the tax net post-demonetization.
- The Economic Survey, Vol. 2 released on 12 August 2017 mentioned that *5.4 lakh* new tax payers were added post-demonetization.
- And finally, the Prime Minister proclaimed in his 2017 Independence Day speech: 'The number of new tax payers filing income tax returns from April 01 to August 05 is *56 lakh* while in the same period last year only 22 lakh filed the returns. In a way it has more than doubled. This is the result of our fight against black money.'

Given the wide variance between 91 lakh and 5.4 lakh new tax payers, there was considerable scepticism about the veracity of this data.

The MoF, scrambling to reconcile the information, put out a press release on 18 August 2017 'clarifying' that there was no inconsistency in the data. They attempted to reconcile the varying statistics as follows:

- 91 lakh of the Finance Minister:[34] 'The statement of the Finance Minister regarding addition of 91 lakh tax payers to the tax-base referred to the total number of new returns filed during the entire FY 2016–17 and therefore, it is neither comparable to the data in